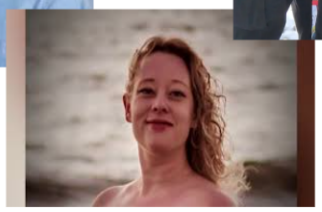
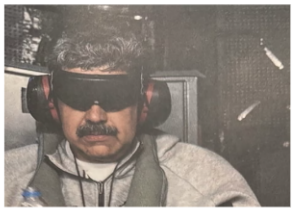
The Importance of Data Context

Over the last 8 weeks...



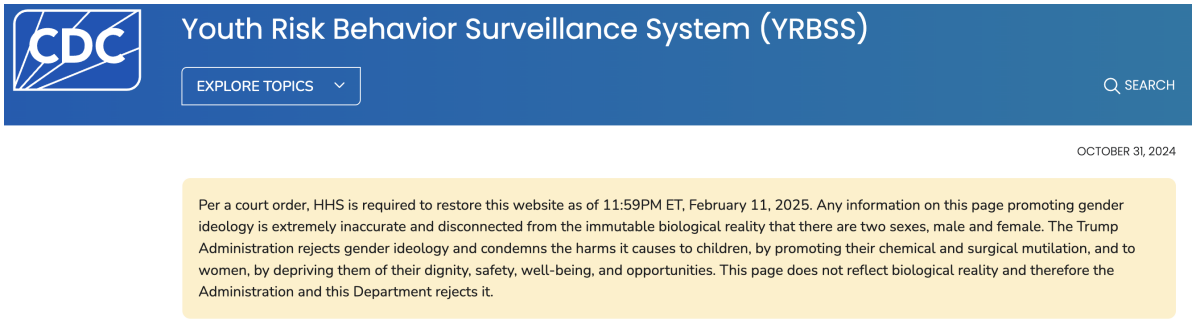


Discussion Norms

- Zero tolerance for: racism, sexism, homophobia, transphobia, ageism, ableism
- Do not make generalizations – Use "I" statements
- Respect one another
- Intent and impact *both* matter
- Non-judgmental
- Embrace discomfort

Data is Power

Data are not neutral or objective. They are the products of unequal social relations, and this context is essential for conducting accurate, ethical analysis.



Discussion Questions

1. Which actors in the data ecosystem are responsible for providing context? End users? Data publishers? Data intermediaries?

2. What steps can we take to ensure context is considered? How can we more effectively present context through data visualization?

3. What are your thoughts (or experiences) on how we label graphs with context?

4. Which power imbalances have led to silences in the dataset or data that are missing altogether?

Data Context

In the "Data Context" section of your Final Poster, you are required to provide a description that directly addresses the:

- social,
- cultural,
- historical,
- institutional, and
- material conditions under which the data were produced.

Ames Housing Data

- What are the social conditions of these data?
  - What are the social influences of owning a house?

- What are the cultural conditions of these data?
  - What is the culture surrounding home ownership in the United States?
  - Does owning a house look the same for everyone?
- What are the historical conditions of these data?
  - What is the history associated with home ownership in the US?
  - What is the history associated with home ownership in Ames, Iowa?

- What are the institutional conditions of these data?
  - What are the institutional forces that factor into home ownership?

- What are the material conditions of these data?
  - How were the data collected?
  - What houses / neighborhoods / individuals are represented in these data? Excluded from these data?